

PHASE 1: Validate Before You Build Goal: *Confirm the project is real, accurate, and not already done.*

☐ Verify the law — Pull actual food waste ban thresholds, exemptions, and 2026 enforcement status directly from RIDEM and the official legislation.

<https://www.climatepolicydashboard.org/policies/industry-materials-waste/food-waste-bans#food-waste-bans-and-targets-by-state>

Food waste ban – The state requires entities to recycle organic waste at authorized composting or anaerobic digestion facilities if they are within 15 miles of an authorized recycling facility, and generate the following amount of food waste per year:

- Higher education and research institutions: at least 52 tons/year
- Other educational entities: at least 30 tons/year
- All other generators: at least 104 tons/year

webserver.rilegislature.gov/Statutes/TITLE23/23-18.9/INDEX.htm (23-18.9-17. Food waste ban)

(d) On and after January 1, 2023, each educational entity (as defined in § 16-111-1) shall ensure that the organic-waste materials that are generated by the educational entity are recycled at an authorized composting facility or anaerobic digestion facility or by another authorized recycling method if:

- (1)** The educational entity generates not less than thirty (30) tons per year of organic-waste material; and
- (2)** The educational entity is located not more than fifteen (15) miles from an authorized composting facility or anaerobic digestion facility with available capacity to accept such material.

History of Section.

P.L. 2014, ch. 184, § 2; P.L. 2014, ch. 210, § 2; P.L. 2016, ch. 481, § 1; P.L. 2016, ch. 498, § 1; P.L. 2021, ch. 344, § 2, effective September 1, 2021; P.L. 2021, ch. 345, § 2, effective September 1, 2021.

[Existing Laws Research Report Draft 8.28.25](#)

[State of Rhode Island General Assembly](#)

☐ Confirm data exists — Check that local hauler/composter service areas, pricing, and capacity are publicly available. If not, simplify the matchmaking feature.

Data is available separately reach out to RIFPC , RIDEM, and CET if they have a more recent dataset

cet-ri-services-providers.pdf

You *can* confirm service areas, accepted materials, and contact info from **public state data**. You *can* confirm compost site capacity and pricing from **RIRRC and Earth Care Farm**. You *can* confirm hauler pricing and capacity **only by contacting them**, but the state dataset gives you all the contact details.

The data doesn't seem to be all compiled in a single location, and not all the details, pricing and capacity being the least accessible for all without needing to contact directly.

☐ Check for duplicates — Search whether RIDEM, RIFPC, or commercial haulers already offer a compliance tool or dashboard.

[Wasted Food Estimation Guide - RecyclingWorks Massachusetts](#) = manual calculator:

What it does:

- Estimates food waste by business type
- Helps determine if a generator exceeds MA's ½-ton/week threshold
- Provides sector-specific generation factors

Why it matters for RI:

- Rhode Island's 104-ton/year threshold is similar enough that this tool is often used informally by RI generators.

Center for EcoTechnology (CET) – Wasted Food Solutions Portal

Region: Multi-state (includes RI)

What it does:

- Lists haulers, compost sites, and diversion options
- Provides RI's official "Service Providers" PDF
- Offers business-type waste estimation guidance

NRDC Food Matters Toolkit :

Region: National

What it does:

- Provides worksheets for estimating food waste
- Includes sector-specific estimation methods

- Offers municipal planning tools

LeanPath Food Waste Tracking (Commercial Software) = this is Automated food waste tracking for kitchens can this be expanded to or localized for state needs?

[Advancing Food Rescue Guide](#)

What are EPA's EFO Map (closest to a locator tool) ?

The tool kits/sources in this section are outdated or original site material is not available

- ☐ Lock in your facts — Save every verified statistic and rule with its source link.

PHASE 2: Define Scope & User *Goal: Make it small enough to actually finish.*

- ☐ Pick ONE core user (e.g., a K-12 school administrator): Categorizing municipal and institutional entities
- ☐ Define your minimum deliverable: just the compliance calculator: not the full architecture.
- ☐ Decide your 15-mile method — Straight-line or driving distance: 15-mile threshold is measured as a **straight-line radius** (GIS mapping as "as the crow flies) to Authorized" Facility only Commercial Composting Facilities, Anaerobic Digestion (AD) Facilities, Permitted Agricultural Operations. tool could be designed to look at the 15-mile radius of the *facilities*, and then recommend the *haulers* who operate in that specific zip code to bridge the gap.
- ☐ Write your one-sentence value statement: "This tool helps calculate food waste tonnage and figure out if you're under or above threshold in under 2 minutes." Ideally direct clients who are above threshold to their nearest facility /service provider within the 15-mile restriction.

PHASE 3: Design Responsibly *Goal: Protect users and yourself.*

- ☐ Add a legal disclaimer — informational only, not legal advice.
- ☐ Handle data privacy — keep inputs session-only or clearly state how data is stored. This may require RIDEM regulation for data tracking for compliance measures
- ☐ Add a plain-English explainer so users learn the law (folds in your original education goal).
- ☐ Build in an impact metric (e.g., "estimated tons diverted") so the climate benefit is visible.

PHASE 4: Plan for Reality *Goal: Show you've thought beyond the demo.*

- ☐ Note a maintenance plan — how would thresholds/facility lists stay current as laws change?
 - ☐ Sketch an adoption path — how does a busy, understaffed user actually find and use this?
 - ☐ List your data sources clearly for your presentation/write-up.
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PHASE 5: Build & Present *Goal: Ship the prototype.*

- ☐ Build the scoped-down prototype.
- ☐ Test with 2–3 realistic example scenarios.
- ☐ Prepare your demo + the "why this matters / why it's not duplicative" story.